

Part I

Patterns of School Segregation and Social Inequalities



School Segregation in France: The Role of Public Policies and Stakeholder Strategies

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1. School segregation in France: an overview

From a scientific and policy standpoint, the issue of school segregation is inextricably linked to the analysis of educational policies. With regard to France, it is useful to understand how segregative phenomena are closely related to specific societal developments and are therefore part of the very functioning of the French educational system. To this end, we shall present three educational policies that are emblematic of the French educational system and that have contributed to school segregation as we see it today. These are the *collège unique* (i.e. comprehensive school), the *carte scolaire* (i.e. school mapping) and the ‘priority education’ policies. All three are part of recent French policy on education and give a fairly accurate picture of its functioning. After a brief introductory presentation of the present state of knowledge on school segregation in France, we shall show how the implementation of these three policies produces effects that indirectly contribute to segregation in the French educational system.

School segregation can be broadly defined as the unequal distribution of the school population according to particular characteristics, such as social origin, ethnic origin, sex or any other ascriptive characteristic. A more restrictive definition considers that spatial separation of pupils in schools, classes, tracks or different ability groups does not suffice to speak of school segregation. Two further conditions are necessary. Firstly, the separation of pupils must lead to specific forms of inequality or exclusion (Barthon, 1998). In this sense, if 95 per cent of the pupils of a school come from privileged socioeconomic backgrounds, this situation cannot be described as segregative. School segregation is therefore characterized by its negative consequences for those individuals who experience and are directly affected by it. One simple demarcation criteria is that in all cases of segregation, individuals have little or no choice: they cannot leave their neighbourhoods or their ghettoized schools because they do not have the economic, social, cultural or regulatory means, as in, for example, the *carte scolaire* (school mapping) system.

Secondly, for segregation to be described as ‘educational’, its consequences must come from ‘the specific actions of the institutions and the educational actors’ (Van Zanten, 2012), and not only result from factors outside the school. This segregation

can be the indirect result of a school policy aimed at grouping pupils into educational units according to their academic level. Numerous studies have shown that tracked educational systems – which separate pupils according to their academic performance – indirectly lead to separation according to adjoining and correlative criteria such as social and ethnic origin. This phenomenon of interweaving segregation has been observed in the United States (Gamoran and Mare, 1989; Lucas and Berends, 2007; Oakes, 1985), Belgium (Franquet et al., 2010), Germany (Baumert et al., 2006; Schnepf, 2002), Switzerland (Felouzis and Charmillot, 2013) and France prior to the Haby reform¹ (Baudelot and Establet, 1971).

School segregation, however, is not necessarily the consequence of an explicit policy of separating pupils. It can also result from more diffuse processes, deeply rooted in society and linked to the combined practices of different social agents. This, rather, is the situation that we encounter in France. The *collège unique* (comprehensive school) was in fact developed to counter the tracked system that prevailed until the mid-1970s. It supported and enabled the democratization of secondary education. However, it did not guarantee social and ethnic diversity in educational institutions for various reasons: the desire of families that their children be educated with members of their own social or ethnic group (Felouzis and Perroton, 2009), urban segregation ‘imported’ into the school through school mapping (Van Zanten, 2012; Oberti, 2007), the development of private education (Merle, 2011a), the diversification of the public educational offer (Barthon and Monfroy, 2006; Trancart, 2000), competition between schools (Broccolichi et al., 2010), uncontrolled easing of school mapping after 2007 (Merle, 2011b), etc. These end-to-end phenomena are not necessarily the result of political will, but rather of a ‘tyranny of small decisions’ (Schelling, 1978) or of social actors’ strategies to optimize their positions (Maresca, 2003).

Research on school segregation in France has come rather late and mostly focus on local geographical spaces (see, for example, Ben Ayed et al., 2013; Fack et al., 2014; Felouzis, 2003; Ly et al., 2014; Merle, 2010; Trancart, 1998). A more complete picture of the extent and structure of school segregation on a national scale has been obtained only very recently, thanks in particular to the work of Ly and Riegert (2015).

Based on data from the Directorate of Evaluation, Foresight and Performance (DEPP) for students enrolled between 2007 and 2013, Ly and Riegert calculated a standardized exposure index. This index estimates the extent to which a group of students are exposed to members of their own group in a given spatial unit. It is therefore a measure of the degree of potential contact between groups within a school. Another property of this index is that it allows us to break down segregation into two sources: between-school and within-school segregation. It is therefore possible to estimate which part of the total segregation is due to differences between the schools and which part is due to the composition of the classes. Using this index, Ly and Riegert were able to measure social and academic segregation in secondary 1 (*collège*) and secondary 2 (*lycée*) education.²

¹ The Haby reform took place in 1975. Secondary 1 education (which is called *collège* in France) went from a tracked system to a comprehensive system (*collège unique*).

² *Collège* lasts for four years, from the sixth (Year 7 in the UK) to the third grade (Year 10). It takes students from the age of 11 to 14. The *Lycée* (sixth form college) lasts for three years: the second (Year 11), the first (Year 12) and the *Terminale* (Year 13); students are between 15 and 17 years of age.

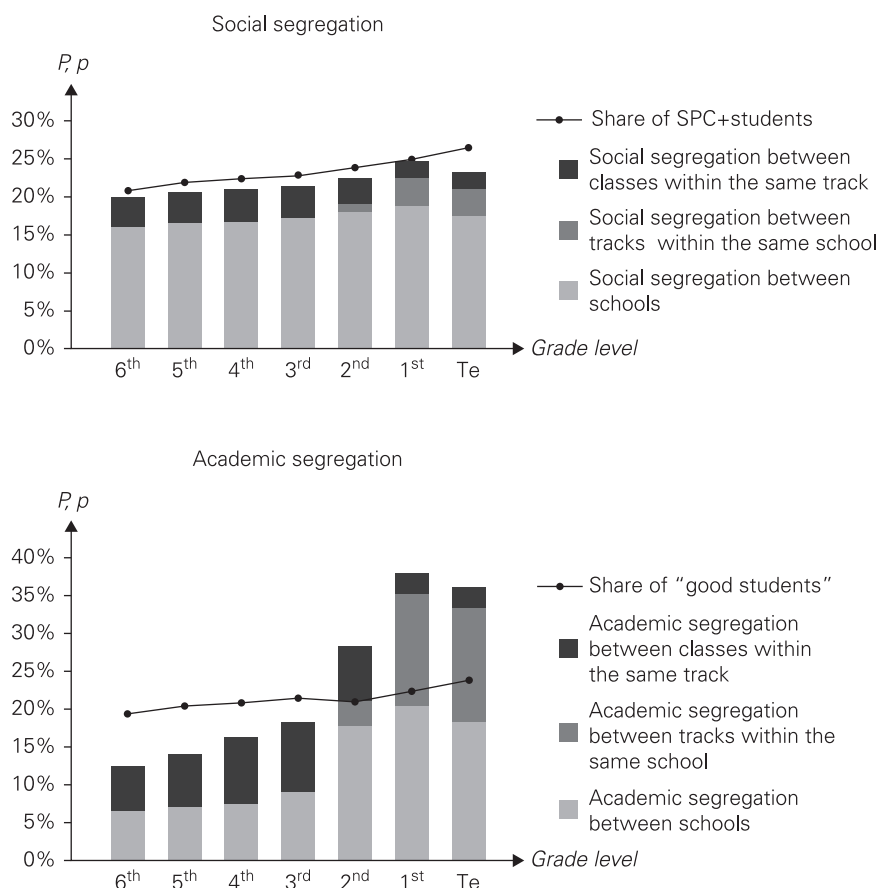


Figure 2.1 Between-school and within-school segregation at the national level, measured by the exposure index for the 2007 cohort. Source: Ly and Riegert, 2015, p. 33.

Notes: 1. This figure should be read as follows: for the cohort of students entering sixth grade in 2007, academic segregation in first grade was 20.6 per cent between schools and 38 per cent between classes. 'Good students' represent 22.4 per cent of the total students.

2. The term 'SPC+' refers to students whose parents belong to the highest socio-professional categories.

3. Sixth grade (Year 6 in the UK) to third grade (Year 10) refers to secondary 1 education (*collège*). Second grade (Year 11) to Te (Year 13) refers to secondary 2 education (*lycée*).

In secondary 1 education, between-school social segregation³ is 16–17 per cent depending on the grade level (Figure 2.1). When within-school social segregation is taken into account, the exposure index increases by 4–6 percentage points depending on the grade level concerned. This decomposition of the total segregation between the between-school and within-school level indicates that within-school segregation has a limited effect, since classroom composition accounts for only about 20 per cent of total segregation.

The authors also measure academic segregation, taking as a reference the proportion of ‘good students’.⁴ In secondary 1 education, between-school academic segregation remains relatively low, varying between 7 per cent and 9 per cent depending on the grade level considered. When class composition is taken into account, academic segregation increases to 13–18 per cent depending on the grade level. The structure of academic segregation is different from that observed for social segregation, since within-school segregation accounts for 50 per cent of the total segregation. In secondary 2 education, academic segregation increases strongly. This sudden increase in the exposure index is mainly due to the separation of pupils into tracks at the start of secondary 2 (general, technological and vocational tracks).

These measurements of social and academic segregation calculated on a national scale conceal strong geographical disparities. A more detailed analysis of social segregation indeed reveals significant variation across regions, with an exposure index ranging from 2 per cent to 27 per cent. The authors note that while within-school segregation varies little from one region to another, between-school segregation appears to be much lower in rural areas. The low population density in rural areas means that schools recruit from larger catchment areas, which encourages social diversity. Conversely, more urbanized regions have higher segregation indices. This is due, on the one hand, to strong residential segregation in urban areas. On the other hand, the geographical proximity between schools has the effect of creating competition, with some schools being more or less avoided, while other schools are highly sought after, which in turn accentuates the effects of residential segregation.

So far, little research has been done in France regarding ethnic segregation, and there are several reasons for this. Firstly, it took France a long time to see itself as ‘a country of immigration’ (Noiriel, 2016). Until the 1970s, foreign workers, mainly from the former French colonies and from southern Europe, were perceived as populations only temporarily present in France and were supposed to return to their country of origin, although this was not what happened in reality. Secondly, during that same period, French sociology was strongly influenced by Marxist theory, which did not allow for thinking in terms of migratory inequalities (van Zanten, 2012). Thirdly, the notion of the French nation, conceived as ‘one and indivisible’ and which considers the

³ Social segregation is measured by taking as reference the most socially advantaged students (SPC+). These are students whose parents belong to the following socio-professional categories: business leaders, liberal professions, civil service, intellectual and artistic professions, business executives, heads of schools, teachers, etc.

⁴ ‘Good students’ are those who have not had to repeat years between the sixth and the fourth grade, who have passed the *brevet* school certificate – a national assessment at the end of the third grade – in the general track and achieved an average within the top 25 per cent of the awarded marks.

citizen in a neutral way (without a singular affiliation), is a brake on reasoning in terms of inequality as linked to the ethnic origins of individuals. Finally, the French statistical system reflects this third point, since the official available databases do not contain information that identifies individuals of immigrant origin (Simon, 2008). Debates around what is known in France as 'ethnic statistics' or the 'statistics of origin' are therefore often heated and virulent, preventing pragmatic reasoning concerning the inequalities linked to the ethnic origin of individuals (Felouzis, 2008).

However, since the early 2000s, research on the links between ethnicity and school segregation has been emerging. Felouzis et al. (2007), for example, studied the social and ethnic segregation in a local context in the southwest of France (Bordeaux Academy) and their analysis highlights the extent of ethnic segregation. Using a concentration index, they calculate the percentage of students who should change schools to have a balanced distribution of students of a given group across all schools. Considering first social origins, they show that 29 per cent of pupils from disadvantaged backgrounds should change schools in order to achieve a balanced distribution. The concentration index increases to 62 per cent for non-native students and, if only students from the Maghreb, Sub-Saharan Africa and Turkey are considered, no less than 89 per cent of pupils should change schools. This concentration of non-native students in certain schools has consequences for their academic results and educational paths. The authors estimate that, all other things being equal, students in schools where the percentage of non-native students exceeds 20 per cent score on average 0.4 points lower (out of 20) in the *brevet* school certificate (Felouzis, 2003).

Recent research in France suggests that academic, social and ethnic segregation is an important factor in explaining inequalities in academic achievement and in educational paths. We shall now discuss three educational policies that were conceived to reduce inequalities, but in fact indirectly contributed to reinforcing school segregation.

2. Educational policies and the question of segregation

2.1 Comprehensive school in France

According to Mons (2007), the *collège unique* (comprehensive school) is defined as 'a school organisation whose primary characteristic is to bring together almost an entire generation within a unique educational structure until the end of the first cycle of secondary education' (p. 89). In order to be considered a comprehensive school, the school system must (1) present a single syllabus without tracking, (2) have comparable schools and (3) offer strictly the same opportunities. However, ever since its inception, the *collège unique* has proposed parallel paths, thus derogating from a comprehensive school model (Prost, 2013). In fact, it was only twenty years after the 1975 Haby reform that schools began to be defined as comprehensive schools. Until then, some pupils continued to be streamed at the end of the fifth and fourth grade towards 'technological' or 'social integration' tracks. Unsurprisingly, orientation towards these non-general tracks was strongly correlated with the social origin of the pupils: whereas 98 per cent of the children of executives entered the general track in the third grade, only 78 per

cent of working-class children did (Mons, 2007). This disparity is not the result of pupils' academic achievement alone, but also of the orientation procedures themselves, which Duru-Bellat and Mingat (1993) have shown to be socially unequal.

The uniformity of education offered in the comprehensive school is also called into question by the presence of certain 'elitist' classes (Vasconcellos and Bongrand, 2013). This is the case, for example, in the 'European' or 'international' classes⁵ in which 5.1 per cent of secondary school pupils were enrolled in 2012. Moreover, the creation of 'preserved classes', a strategy used by some schools, particularly segregated ones, to retain families who have the symbolic and economic means to choose other schools, also contributes to the erosion of the idea of a comprehensive school. This is the case, for example, in the 'scheduled classes' (CHAM), which provide artistic education or sports-study classes.

These distinctions through the choice of options contribute to reinforce segregation by creating situations of competition between public schools within the same geographical area in order to attract (or retain) the 'best' students. It also has important repercussions for a school career (Duru-Bellat and van Zanten, 2012). For example, 26 per cent of school teachers' children take German as their first language, compared to only 8 per cent of children of working-class and unemployed parents. Thus, although it is theoretically no longer possible to distinguish between different tracks in secondary 1 education, in reality, the choice of options reintroduces a strong distinction between classes within schools and between pupils' educational paths. For Ly et al. (2014), this is one of the main sources of within-school segregation, since 'of the 16% of social segregation ... which cannot be explained by chance, 62% ... can be explained by the distribution of options in classes. If schools did not create their classes according to pupils' choices of options, two thirds of the segregation cases might not have taken place' (p. 5).

Thus, in the early 1980s, in his preface to Paty's work, *12 colleges in France* (1981), Crozier noted that differentiation according to tracking, which prevailed prior to the Haby reform, had already been replaced by the differentiation of the schools. The idea was that schools became the functional substitutes for tracks. This analysis has not been contradicted, since schools are today highly differentiated according to the academic, social and ethnic nature of their student body. In a recent book, Ben Ayed (2015) argues that behind a unifying discourse lies a strong resistance to the comprehensive school, legitimizing the separation of pupils and the differentiation of educational paths. He pointed out that 'during the contemporary period, educational policies always articulated a seemingly unifying discourse, while emphasising the need for differentiation in teaching to adapt to the "diversity" of the pupils. Recently, one of the central themes of the school debate was the criticism and the questioning of the comprehensive school' (Ben Ayed, 2015, p. 16). Comprehensive school thus continues to be controversial, both for policy makers and for parents who doubt its effectiveness (Mons, 2007).

⁵ European and international classes focus on learning a foreign language. The European sections teach the chosen language for an extra two hours per week. The international sections offer specific courses in history-geography and literature of the language concerned.

Finally, it should be noted that although no structural reform has changed the organization of the comprehensive school over the last twenty years, this does not mean that it has not evolved. During this period, the practices and the implementations of certain mechanisms have modified its organization. In particular, there has been a homogenization in the educational offer, related to the ending of certain tracks in secondary 1, and a significant drop in repetition rates (Caille, 2014). This has had a positive impact on the educational paths of students in secondary 1 education, which have become more linear, and on their orientations in secondary 2, with an increase in orientations towards general and technological tracks. However, the effects of this homogenization on equity must be put into perspective, as options continue to be available. Moreover, along with this homogenization in the educational offer, there is a strong diversification at the territorial level, producing an amplification of school segregation (see, for example, Barthou and Monfroy, 2006; Trancart, 2000).

2.2 The *carte scolaire*: a tool against segregation?

One cannot really describe the *carte scolaire* (school mapping) as a 'school policy'. Rather, it could be seen as a series of provisions aimed at matching educational facilities, on the one hand, and families' schooling needs, on the other, within a given local area. Introduced in 1963, the general underlying principle of school mapping was to condition the assignment of a pupil to a particular public school based on where she or he lives. The primary function of school mapping was to regulate the flow of pupils among schools, but gradually it was assigned another objective: to ensure social diversity.

However, research on the effects of school mapping yields an identical finding: it contributes little to fostering the mixing of diverse groups of pupils. In the best of cases, school mapping merely reproduces the segregation of the residential space in the educational space. In some cases, it even helps accentuate segregation further still. This is what is meant, for example, when Oberti (2007) argues that 'school mapping applies unequally to different social groups. It reinforces the protection of the most favoured, weakens social diversity in the ordinary schools, and finally accentuates the relegation and disqualification of the most disadvantaged' (p. 262). One can therefore question the reasons for the inability of school mapping to ensure social diversity.

A first explanation is that its student management objectives are more important than any social objectives. Van Zanten and Obin (2008) consider that this system has been more effective in its role of regulating student flows than in preserving social diversity in schools. Moreover, the history and the evolution of school mapping as reported by these two authors show that school mapping has never been as rigid as intended. Unlike in South Korea, Japan or Greece, school mapping in France has always been deployed along with a possibility of derogation (Mons, 2007).

A second explanation is related to the size of school catchment areas. As the school catchment areas operate on a reduced territorial basis, school mapping can therefore contribute to diversity only where residential segregation also involves small spatial units: small neighbourhoods, islets, etc. If residential segregation involves larger units, for example at the municipality level, school mapping will have no effect, except to replicate the structure of the residential space in the school space. In other words, the areas of

recruitment where the most disadvantaged pupils reside are too large and too homogeneous for school mapping to have any real effect in terms of diversity (Oberti, 2005).

The segregative effects of school mapping also come from the strategies of parents who seek to enrol their children in schools other than those imposed on them by the catchment area they are living in. These avoidance strategies contribute to the reinforcement of school segregation for two reasons. On the one hand, because the schools which are most avoided have a higher proportion of pupils from immigrant and disadvantaged backgrounds. On the other hand, it is mainly wealthier parents who possess the economic and cultural means to implement these strategies.

These avoidance practices can take many forms. A first way of avoiding a school catchment area is to move to an area that guarantees assignment to a preferred school. In a study of the Paris region, Korsu (2004) shows that these practices remain marginal. He estimates that the rate of students who leave the local public sector following a move at the end of primary school is only 5–6 per cent of the total number of pupils and that the number of moves that are really for educational reasons is probably even lower.

While avoidance by moving is limited, it still raises the question of the interaction between schools and residential choice. Oberti and Barthón (2000) indicate that the choice of housing, especially in large cities, is increasingly dependent on schools and not just on the proximity of work and the family. Thus, 'the classic elements of urban segregation (property market logic, gentrification of city centres, housing policies, income inequalities, location of enterprises and investments, etc.) would be supplemented by a dimension related to the choice of schools' (p. 308). There is therefore not only an impact of urban segregation on school segregation, but also a 'backward effect' of school segregation on urban segregation (Fack and Grenet, 2009). Control of space (access to local resources, place of residence, mobility) would thus become a resource in its own right (Oberti, 2005; François and Poupeau, 2009). This means that the advantages associated with spatial position are not only symbolic (Pinçon and Pinçon-Charlot, 2009), but also offer 'added value' to access the public and private resources of the school. Control of this spatial dimension thus represents a 'spatial capital', which, like cultural capital, contributes to the reproduction of school inequalities (Barthón and Monfroy, 2011).

Derogations are another means used to circumvent school catchment areas. Parents may request that their child be enrolled in a school other than that imposed on them by school mapping. These requests for derogation are often justified for organizational reasons (proximity to the workplace, presence of another family member, etc.), but they can also be used informally to control the school attended by the child. Various studies carried out on the use of derogations show that the proportion of pupils enrolled in public institutions outside the sector remains a minority. Chausseron (2001) indicates that this affects about 10 per cent of French pupils enrolled in the fifth grade. However, these requests for derogations are likely to vary considerably depending on the geographical area, and are particularly noticeable in urban areas. For example, Maresca (2003) estimates that in some municipalities in the Paris region, more than half of families seek to avoid the public school imposed upon them at the end of primary school.

Finally, some families resort to private education in order to bypass their catchment area. Chausseron (2001) indicates that 20 per cent of families use private education, again with important differences depending on the geographical location. In Paris, for example, the share of the private sector reached 34 per cent at the beginning of secondary 1 (Gillotte and Girard, 2005).

Even if avoidance strategies concern only a minority of students, they nevertheless produce effects that contribute to the accentuation of school segregation. This occurs firstly because only certain schools are the object of these avoidance strategies. The most requested schools are generally characterized by a high proportion of pupils who did not repeat years and by a limited presence of pupils from immigrant or disadvantaged backgrounds (van Zanten, 2012). Indeed, in the absence of clear information on the quality of schools, family choice depends on the reputation of the schools, which is collectively constructed within 'judgement networks' (Felouzis and Perroton, 2007). The criteria that define the educational level of a school is therefore filtered by the social and ethnic characteristics of its public. Because of its visibility, ethnic origin in particular is an indicator of the social identity of a school, and although it is rarely mentioned explicitly, it is often a reason for circumvention. Thus, 'the ethnic criteria may ultimately summarise risky school contexts for the avoiding families' (Lorcerie, 2003, p. 94).

Secondly, avoidance strategies are conditioned by the resources available to families. It is mainly wealthier parents who possess the economic and cultural means to implement these strategies. Conversely, parents from disadvantaged backgrounds are 'captives' of the system, having neither the financial means to afford private education for their children, nor the 'skills', and particularly access to information, to enable these strategies.

In the end, strategies to avoid designated school catchment areas contribute to reinforcing school segregation because 'bad schools' are perceived to have a high proportion of pupils of immigrant and disadvantaged backgrounds and because the more favoured families manage to escape these schools. However, pupil transfers, resulting from avoidance strategies, do not universally have the same effect. As Felouzis' analysis (2005) on segregation in the Bordeaux academy shows, the consequences for school segregation are greatest in the most disadvantaged urban areas:

In the wealthiest catchment areas, there is a game of musical chairs: the secondary school of the catchment area is not filled with local students, who are now in private education, but takes those from other catchment areas. This is a neutral operation for the school in terms of number of students as well as social and ethnic composition of its public. In the most stigmatised schools, what is lost to one side is not compensated by the other. The loss of pupils is either to the private sector or to other schools, without the contribution of other pupils compensating for these losses. There is then a process of self-reproducing segregation.

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Faced with the impossibility of school mapping to deliver diversity, certain politicians, such as Nicolas Sarkozy in 2007, proposed relaxing school mapping in order to promote

greater freedom of choice. Merle (2011a, b) evaluated the effect of this relaxation of school mapping in three French cities (Paris, Bordeaux and Lille) and observed an increase in the avoidance of the most disadvantaged schools to the benefit of schools which recruit from the most favoured social categories, mechanically producing a reinforcement of the segregative phenomenon.

The easing of school mapping in 2007 was accompanied by measures designed to guarantee social diversity. In particular, that requests for derogations from scholarship students should be given priority over requests from wealthier families wishing to change schools on the grounds of preference or geographical proximity.⁶ However, an analysis conducted by Merle (2011a) shows not only that scholarship students rarely request derogation, but also that this criterion was not automatically given priority over other reasons. The author concludes that there is a phenomenon of 'relative, or even absolute, ghettoisation for the most disadvantaged schools, combining a loss of enrolment and loss of pupils from advantaged backgrounds' (p. 47). In order to continue to attract students from advantaged backgrounds and to reduce their flight to more favoured schools, the separation of pupils in different classes according to their academic level has been further strengthened in these schools. Between-school segregation is therefore complemented by within-school segregation whose negative effects have been demonstrated both on pupils' competences (Duru-Bellat and Mingat, 1997; Ly et al., 2014), and on non-cognitive dimensions such as discipline (Debarbieux, 1996) or educational well-being (Fouquet-Chauprade, 2014). In his evaluation of the effect of the easing of the catchment areas in the Rennes academy, Merle (2011b) also shows that 2000–06 was characterized by a period of gentrification of the private schools, while the period following the easing of school mapping (2006–09) was characterized by an increase in social segregation.

2.3 'Priority education' policies: tackling the consequences of school segregation

Priority education policies are directly associated with policies to combat the effects of segregation. In France, they do not aim to prevent segregation, nor do they seek desegregation (as is the case, for example, of the USA or South Africa). Instead, they are intended only to mitigate or even eliminate its most negative consequences. It should be noted that the choices made in France in terms of 'positive discrimination' for students from disadvantaged backgrounds focus on a territorialized policy. Therefore, they are not about acting in favour of socially disadvantaged groups, but they are rather targeting disadvantaged areas, because of higher proportions of students from disadvantaged backgrounds and with academic difficulties.

We do not intend to trace back the history of this policy⁷ which first saw the light of day in France in the early 1980s. Rather, we shall focus on its evolution over the last

⁶ If parents request a derogation, it is accepted only if there are places available in the requested school. If the number of applications for a school exceeds its capacity, priority is given to students receiving a scholarship.

⁷ On this point, see, for example, the work of Robert (2009).

twenty years. Merle (2012) demonstrates the rapid proliferation of priority education. In 1997, the Priority Education Zones (ZEP) educated 14.3 per cent of the pupils in secondary 1 education. At the beginning of the 1997–98 school year, and following the Moisan and Simon report (1997), the ZEP became the Priority Education Networks (ZEP-REP). Seven years later, 20.4 per cent of the students were educated through these networks. Aware of the dilution of resources and the low relevance of such a facility, the Ministry of Education decided in 2006 on the creation of an Ambition for Success Network (RAR), which had to allow a refocusing of resources on a smaller number of schools: less than 5 per cent of pupils in secondary 1 education were enrolled in RAR. However, the ZEP-REP did not disappear and became the School Success Networks (SSN), which concerned 15 per cent of students. The new RAR policy aimed at concentrating more resources towards the schools that were most in need. However, overlaying the RAR and ZEP-REP tended to blur the message. In 2010 the *Collège and Lycée for ambition, innovation and success* (CLAIR) appeared, which was more explicitly aimed at improving school climate. This system extended to primary schools the following year (ECLAIR). In 2011, the majority of the RAR disappeared.

This demonstrates that priority education has become increasingly complex by superimposing recent measures onto older ones. Moreover, since the early 1990s, priority education policies have been linked to urban policies, which further complicates their implementation, but probably gives more coherence to the fight against school inequalities (Lorcerie, 2010). At the same time, specific mechanisms are added to these policies (refresher courses, educational support, etc.) organized by the local authorities or the schools themselves.

The so-called ‘refounding’ of the school policy established in 2014, which aimed at reducing inequalities and promoting the success of all, tried to reduce this overlapping of measures and to refocus efforts on a smaller number of schools by thoroughly revising the catchment areas. The other objective was that of a ‘rubbing out’ of threshold effects. This policy established REP+ which focused mainly on pedagogical innovation and the modification of teachers’ working time by granting them non-teaching hours to promote collective work, consultation, etc.

Ultimately, these priority education policies face a major challenge: the confusion between the objectives of the policies and the means by which they can be achieved (Robert, 2009). They aim to restore equality between students by combating the deleterious effects of segregation, even though the nature and sources of the phenomena on which they want to act are very disparate (Fouquet-Chauprade and Dutrévis, 2015). This leads to a profusion of objectives and measures that hinder their effectiveness: do we want to take action on class sizes, on the construction of innovative pedagogical projects, on collective works, on school-family relations or on the school climate? Many of the objectives of priority education are therefore vague and variously measurable. An evaluation report by the DEPP (CIMAP, 2013) notes that ‘priority education has gradually been assigned a wide range of operational objectives, both for pupils and their families (social, health, cultural, educational, orientation, vocational integration objectives, etc.), without these being truly formalised, nor always implemented, nor truly evaluated’ (p. 16).

Assessments of these priority education policies are rather nuanced or even negative in terms of their effects on inequalities in competences and orientation, as well as on

the school climate (see, for example, Armand and Gille, 2006; Meuret, 1994; Moisan and Simon, 1997). Moreover, 'labelling effects' are far from being anecdotal, since the system leads to a process of stigmatization of the schools and pupils attending those schools, ultimately causing an increase in school segregation (Fouquet-Chauprade and Dutrévis, 2015; Merle, 2012). Finally, far from being a policy of combating segregation, priority education ends up being a 'source of social and academic segregation' (Merle, 2012, p. 63). Schools integrating priority education are avoided by families who can afford to do so (van Zanten, 2012), students who attend these schools are stigmatized (Fouquet-Chauprade, 2014; Merle, 2012), academic expectations are revised downwards, and the school climate is often tense, even violent (Debarbieux, 1996).

3. Conclusion

The three distinct school policies that we have examined in relation to school segregation are similar in a number of ways.

Firstly, all three policies, each in their own way and to varying degrees, try to establish a system of compulsory education that is as unified and egalitarian as possible. This is indeed the leading principle of the *collège unique*, one of the goals of the *carte scolaire* and the main objective of priority education.

Secondly, they all fail in doing so, either because their objectives are not always explicit, or because the means implemented are not sufficiently directly linked to these objectives. The case of the comprehensive school is exemplary. The Haby reform of 1975 aimed at accompanying school massification (assuming that this would lead to the democratization of education) and limiting social inequalities in access to the *baccalauréat*. However, from the 1980s onwards, differentiation between schools was such that it was necessary to establish a priority education policy as early as 1981. The latter was intended to limit inequalities in learning outcomes and educational paths between pupils linked to social segregation between schools. Successive evaluation reports and ad hoc studies have shown that this objective has not been achieved, indicating that giving more resources to segregated schools is not enough to reduce educational inequalities.

Finally, the way in which these policies are implemented produces perverse effects which contribute to reinforcing segregation. This is particularly the case of school mapping. Its application, avoidance and relaxation all too often lead to confine disadvantaged and immigrant students to less attractive schools, while other students succeed in avoiding them. This is also the case with the priority education policy which does not aim to combat segregation, the risk being to legitimize it under the pretext of fighting against its consequences.

The question then arises of how to explain this very singular situation of the French educational system with regard to the persistence and the extent of educational segregation and the consequent inequalities. The sources of the problem are, of course, multiple and one cannot reduce them to a single cause. They are the consequences of the actions of all actors involved in the educational field: parents, teachers, administrators, and policy makers. Yet it is clear from our analysis of public education

policies that many of the choices made in the past have not improved equity in school. For a long time, it had been thought possible to combat school inequalities by promoting a double process: massification and compensation.

Massification, which consisted of an unprecedented opening of secondary and higher education, was supposed to bring egalitarian qualities. While this may be true regarding access to the *baccalauréat* for all tracks, this is not true for the 'elite' tracks in secondary 2 and higher education. This is also not the case for school achievement at the end of primary and secondary 1 education, which today depends more on the ascriptive characteristics of pupils (their social origin, their migratory path, their sex, etc.) than it did before (Felouzis et al., 2016).

Compensation is linked to the fact that massification – in particular, in secondary 1 education – was very quickly carried out in a segregative manner. From the beginning of the 1980s, this segregative massification produced schools in which the conditions for education were unfavourable through the sheer concentration of social, economic and educational problems. The idea was therefore to compensate for this cumulative disadvantage by the allocation of a surplus of human and operational resources to these schools. However, these compensation policies did not produce the desired effects. They failed to limit inequality of achievement and of educational paths between students, because they merely distributed resources instead of focusing on student learning.

School segregation is a powerful factor in the production of inequality. It produces conditions that are unfavourable to learning through the effects of the school climate, the composition of the school public and the quality of teaching. A school policy aimed at limiting the extent of inequality in student achievement would explicitly target segregation and would have as its primary objective diversity in schools – that is to say, coexistence of pupils of all academic levels within the same educational units, until the end of compulsory education. Finally, all these findings call for real policies of desegregation which are still missing in France.

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